

## How Nikon uses Rhetoric in the Stunningnikon Ad Campaign

Rhetoric is the way people communicate persuasively, and the tools they use to enhance their persuasion. There are a few ways to investigate that rhetoric. The main one we will be looking into is the “rhetorical situation,” which can be split into five main parts: Genre, rhetors, audience, constraints, and exigence (GRACE). Another way to look at rhetoric that needs to be discussed are the three “artistic appeals” created by Aristotle in the fourth century BCE. They are Logos, Pathos, and Ethos. Logos is appealing to logic and reason; Pathos is when the rhetoric is appealing to emotion; and Ethos is the way the rhetoric enhances the credibility and authority of the rhetor. (Carroll, 2010).

In the November 2006 issue of *Macworld* magazine, page 31 features a full-page advertisement from Nikon. This ad is part of their Stunningnikon campaign, where Nikon sent two hundred cameras to the residents of Georgetown, South Carolina and used the resulting photos in their marketing material (Lippert, 2007).

**Figure 1**

*Advertisement for Nikon*



*Note.* The ad features a blurb in the middle of the page, talking about the people who took the photos, with a short description of the camera used. Along with a link to the ad campaign's website. The rest of the advertisement is four photos with webpage links featuring the first names of photographers.

This advertisement uses different aspects of the rhetorical situation to convince the reader that they should buy the Nikon D80. Nikon bought a full-page advertisement; they want you to see it, even if you skim. They show that the average Joe can take excellent pictures, even without technical skills. And they invite you to explore the camera further, with personal web links that add credibility to the exigence.

Genre is the form the rhetoric takes: the language it uses, the way it's transmitted or communicated, its imagery. If it's an ad, is it on tv, or social media? An opinion piece could be in a newspaper, or a YouTube video essay. When discussing the purpose of pathos in rhetoric, Carroll (2010) states that "Emotional appeals can come in many forms – an anecdote or narrative, an image such as a photograph, or even humor" (p.53). Appeals; whether that be logical (logos) or emotional (pathos), take many different forms, and those forms would be the genre. It is important to mention that audience is related to the Genre of rhetoric, as often the Genre is chosen to cater to the audience. The audience is those on the receiving end of the rhetoric. The audience doesn't have to be the intended audience; it includes anyone who would want to engage in rhetoric. "Another part of the rhetorical context is audience, those who are the (intended or unintended) recipients of the rhetorical message.", "In other words, the audience should be able to help address the problem" (Carroll, 2010, p.49). Now to look at the ad through this lens, its primary audience is amateur photographers. Those who mainly do it as more of a hobby, it's not their job, so they most likely lack the skill to properly use other, more expensive models. Those who "shoot for family photo albums" Nikon (2006). Nikon chose the genre of a full-page ad, featuring photos from the subjects in their campaign. Like Heather's cute dog or Timothy's funky bench. This enhances the attraction to their desired audience because it's eye catching and the photos are attractive. Once you've been sucked in, and you read some more, you find these awesome photos aren't taken by professionals.

## Rhetors

The next part of GRACE is rhetors, and they are the people making and broadcasting rhetoric. They're the ones who want you to be persuaded by something. Carroll (2010) supports this idea when explaining purpose as part of the 'rhetorical triangle': "We can discern the purpose by asking questions like 'what does the rhetor want me to believe after seeing this message?' or 'what does the rhetor want me to do?'" (p.52). The primary rhetor is Nikon, since they are the ones who made the ad. Per Nikon's website, their imaging business brings "enjoyment to people around the world" and that their cameras "capture crucial moments in high-quality images" (*Imaging Products Business | Corporate Information | Nikon about Us*, n.d.). Nikon wants you to buy the D80, so you too can have your crucial moments captured in

high-quality. Because they bought the ad spot, that makes them the primary rhetor. But they're not the only rhetor. Because the ad is in a magazine, the magazine is also a rhetor because they are the ones who are transmitting the advertisement. *Macworld*, by its name, is primarily targeted towards Macintosh users. Apple, which manufactures the Macintosh line of products, has a reputation as a luxury, but friendly brand. And lastly there are the people whose photographs are being featured, and a bit more abstractly, the dog being cute. Their photos are being used to show how good the camera is, even when used by everyday amateur photographers.

### Constraints

The constraints are the ways the rhetoric will be changed to persuade the intended audience more effectively, based on the limitations with the transmission of the rhetoric. The rhetors need to be able to adapt their rhetoric for different situations, [constraints] “may be far more complex like the kinds of language you need to use to persuade a certain community.” (Carroll, 2010, p. 49). This ad prioritizes the space for photos. But of the three in the magazine, it's the most balanced. This one has an effective paragraph, but also attractive photos that still manage to take up most of the space. One weird constraint that's appeared now that it's going to be 20 years old in a few months, is that “stunningnikon.com” is not a domain that's owned by Nikon anymore. So, unless you've heard of tools like the [Wayback Machine](#), you're not going to be able to see the other photos from the campaign. (And even then, it doesn't work very well, as the site was made with Adobe Flash). But aside from those, a big one is that there were a lot of photos taken as part of the campaign. There might've been a lot of great ones to showcase in the full-page magazine ad, but they had to narrow down to just four. Or on the flipside it could've been that these were a stretch to get. But according to the users on the forum page I list [below](#), they were apparently mostly good.

### Exigence

Exigence is the situation the rhetoric is trying to address, which is likely some sort of problem. “What is this rhetoric responding to?” “What might have happened to make the rhetor (the person who creates the rhetoric) respond in this way?” (Carroll, 2010, p. 48-49). The whole idea of this ad is that amateur photographers can get amazing photos from using this camera. “They shoot for family photo albums,” “See more of the jaw-dropping highlights at [stunningnikon.com/dslr](#).” That's how they're trying to convince you to buy the camera. It's naturally very hard for a company to sell an expensive, enthusiast product to amateurs. But this is fascinating, and I think it is a very effective way to get people interested in a product that may normally be too expensive for them.

### References

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